

Explaining the Persistent Gender Pay Gap in Singapore's IT Sector

A Mixed-Methods Research Proposal



Why Does the Gender Pay Gap Persist in Singapore's IT Sector?

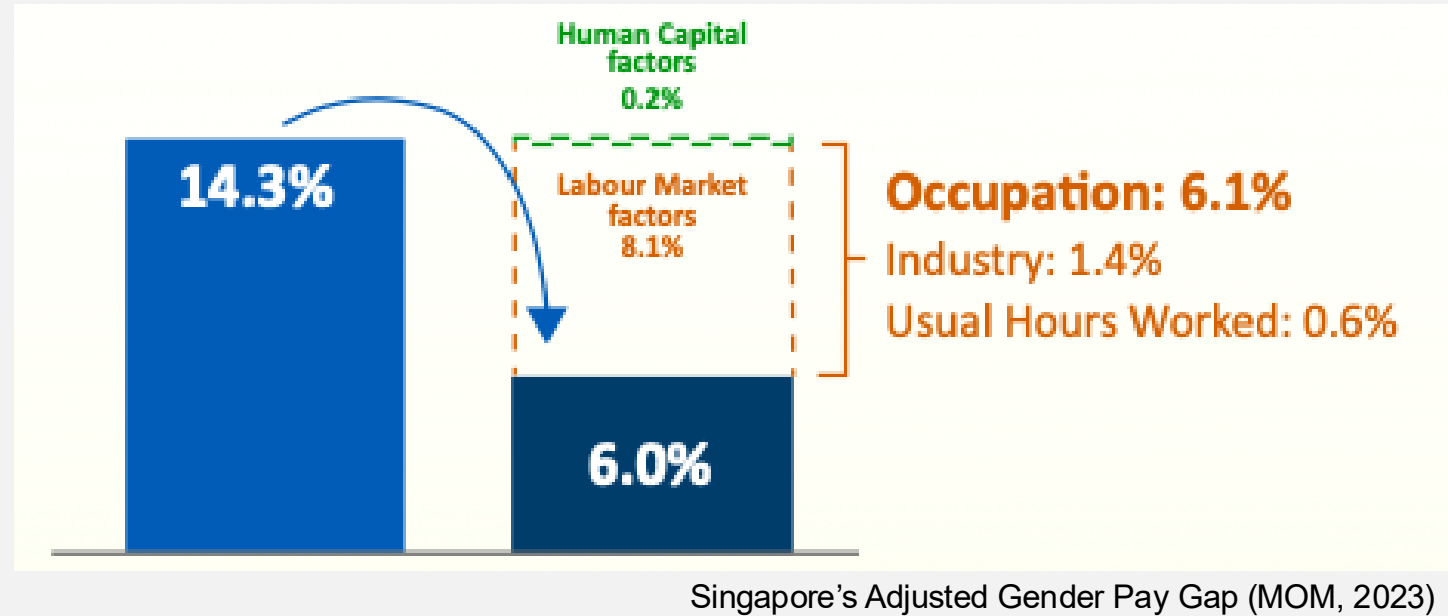
Research Problem

- Persistent gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector (MOM, 2023; OECD, 2024)
- Gap remains after controlling for education and experience (Lin et al., 2020)
- Most pronounced in senior and specialist roles (Ridgeway, 2011)

Significance

- IT central to Singapore's Smart Nation strategy (IMDA, 2023)
- Policy responses prioritise skills over organisational power (MOM, 2023; WEF, 2024)
- Risks continued under-utilisation of female talent (Heilman, 2012)

Explaining the 'Unexplained' Gender Pay Gap in Singapore



Key Insight

- Unadjusted gender pay gap: **14.3%**
- Adjusted gap remains: **6.0%**
- Human capital explains only a small proportion

Research Question

To what extent do organisational and structural inequalities explain the persistent gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector beyond human capital factors?

-  How does occupational segregation shape wage outcomes in IT roles?
-  What organisational practices influence promotion and pay progression for women?
-  Where do human capital explanations fall short in explaining senior-level pay gaps?



**Human Capital Theory
(Becker, 1993)
Gender Inequality Theory
(Ridgeway, 2011)**

Aims and Objectives

To critically evaluate competing explanations for the gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector, with particular emphasis on organisational and structural inequalities.



Quantitative Analysis

Analyse secondary wage and employment data by gender, occupation, and seniority within Singapore's IT sector

(MOM, 2023; OECD, 2024)



Organisational Analysis

Identify organisational and structural barriers affecting promotion and pay progression through document analysis

(Ridgeway, 2011; Heilman, 2012)



Theoretical Evaluation

Critically assess the explanatory power of Human Capital Theory versus Gender Inequality Theory

(Becker, 1993; Ridgeway, 2011)



Practical Implications

Derive implications for policy design and organisational practice within Singapore's IT sector

(WEF, 2024; PwC, 2022)

Competing Explanations of the Gender Pay Gap

Human Capital Theory (HCT) by *Becker (1993)*

- Wage differences reflect education, skills, experience
- Emphasises individual investment and labour market entry
- Influential in policy and economic modelling

VS

Gender Inequality Theory (GIT) by *Ridgeway (2011)*

- Inequality embedded in organisational structures
- Promotion, role allocation, and power dynamics matter
- Explains persistence beyond entry-level roles

Supporting Organisational Evidence

- Promotion bias and sponsorship gaps (Ibarra et al., 2010)
- Gender stereotypes in evaluation and leadership (Heilman, 2012)

Mixed-Methods Research Design



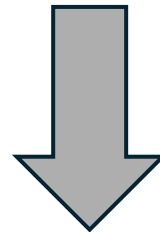
Quantitative Component

- Secondary wage and employment data
- Descriptive and comparative analysis by gender, role, and seniority
(*MOM, 2023; OECD, 2024*)



Qualitative Component

- Thematic analysis of policy, organisational documents and industry frameworks
- Focus on promotion, role allocation, and pay progression
(*Braun & Clarke, 2006*)



**Triangulation to compare human capital vs
organisational explanations**

Risk and Ethics

   **No participants**

 **Public data**

 **Minimal risk**

 **Ethical compliance**

Description of Artefact(s)

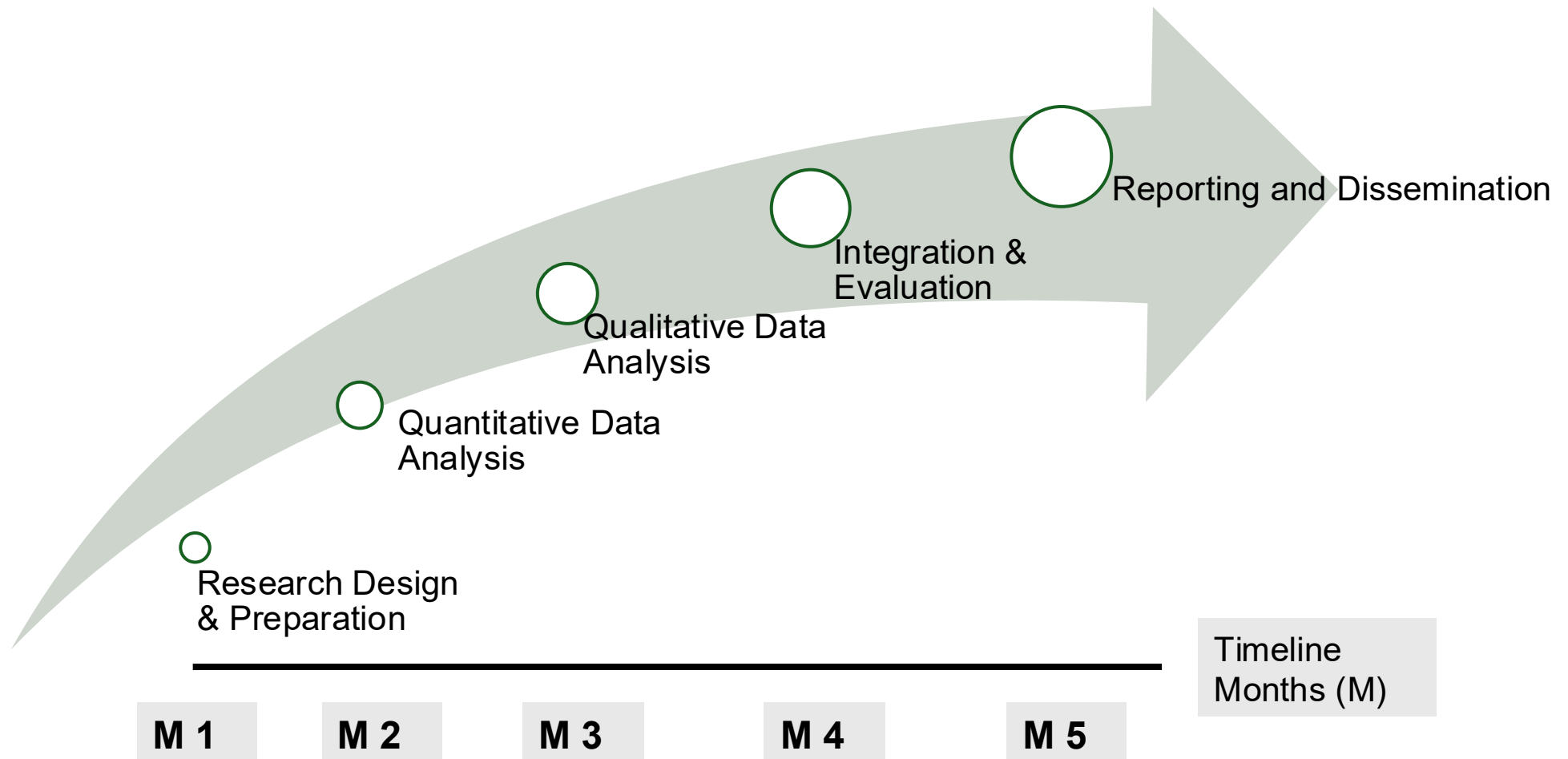
Primary Research Artefact

- Structured **research proposal**
- Mixed-methods research design
- Theoretically grounded analytical framework

Supporting Outputs

- Synthesised comparative analysis of wage data
- Thematic framework of organisational mechanisms
- Evidence-based recommendations for policy and practice

Timeline



Conclusion & Outlook

Contribution

- Advances understanding of gender pay inequality in Singapore's IT sector
- Bridges labour market data with organisational theory
- Mixed-methods enables comparison of competing explanations

Strengths and Limitations

- + Feasible within MSc timeframe
- + Minimal ethical risk
- + Theoretical and data triangulation
- No primary organisational data
- Reliance on published narratives
- Limited insight into firm-level practices

Outlook

- Scalable to interviews and organisational case studies
- Deeper analysis of promotion and pay-setting processes
- Potential for sector-specific or firm-level comparison

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